

Im Eshkachech

436a

Version 2

Trad
Arr. Stuart Izon

Traditionally we break a glass under the chuppah and sing Im Eshkahech. The origin of this custom is not entirely clear: there are two accounts in the Gemara (Brachot 30b) of Rabbis who broke a vessel in order to maintain an air of solemnity in the midst of a joyous occasion. It seems that breaking the glass is unrelated to mourning for Jerusalem, and even as late as the 13th century, this was the generally understood meaning.

Elsewhere, the Talmud lists a number of practices to commemorate the destruction of the Temple, including placing ashes on a groom's forehead on his wedding day; breaking a glass isn't explicitly mentioned in the Gemara. The Kolbo suggests the custom developed to break a glass under the chuppah as an alternative to placing ashes where tefillin are worn, since many had become lax in wearing tefillin regularly. Over the years the practice has become linked with mourning the Temple. This custom is so deeply rooted that it was even practiced by the Mexican conversos (who lost nearly all Jewish customs), and also by the Bene Israel of India.

Surprisingly there are no versions of Im Eshkachech in any works by the major Jewish composers, which may indicate it was typically read and not sung. Here is what is known as the traditional wedding melody; this wistfully sad melody is of unknown origin. Whilst more modern tunes have their place, no other melody tugs at the heartstrings quite as much as this, as we complete the chuppah service and remember Jerusalem.

Andante

Chazzan

Im esh - ka - chech y' - ru - sha - la - yim tish -

Melody Alto

Im esh - ka - chech y' - ru - sha - la - yim tish -

Tenor Bass

6

C.

-kach y' - mi - ni im esh - ka - chech y' -

M A

-kach y' - mi - ni im esh - ka - chech y' -

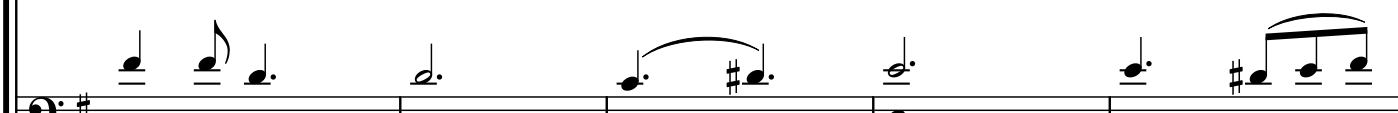
T B

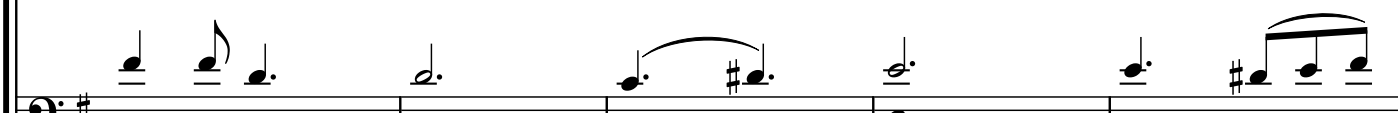
11

C. 
 8 -ru - sha - la - yim tish - - kach y' - mi -

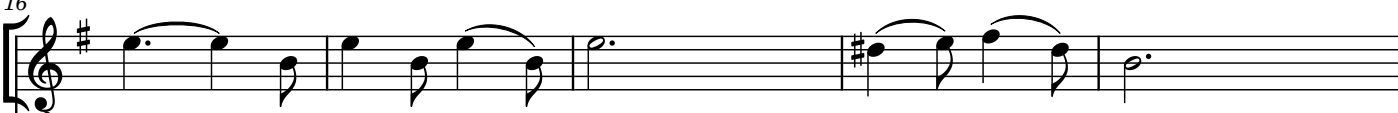
M 
 8 -ru - sha - la - yim tish - kach y' - mi -

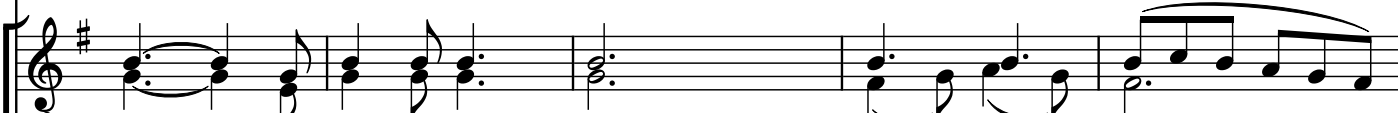
A 
 8 -ru - sha - la - yim tish - kach y' - mi -

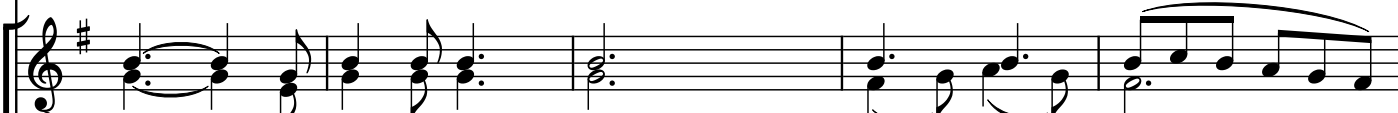
T 
 8 -ru - sha - la - yim tish - kach y' - mi -

B 
 8 -ru - sha - la - yim tish - kach y' - mi -

16

C. 
 8 -ni tid - bak l' - sho - ni l' - chi - ki

M 
 8 -ni tid - bak l' - sho - ni l' - chi - ki

A 
 8 -ni tid - bak l' - sho - ni l' - chi - ki

T 
 8 -ni tid - bak l' - sho - ni l' - chi - ki

B 
 8 -ni tid - bak l' - sho - ni l' - chi - ki

21

C. 
 8 im lo ez - k' - rei - chi im lo a' - a -

M 
 8 im lo ez - k' - rei - chi im lo a' - a -

A 
 8 im lo ez - k' - rei - chi im lo a' - a -

T 
 8 im lo ez - k' - rei - chi im lo a' - a -

B 
 8 im lo ez - k' - rei - chi im lo a' - a -

26

C.

8 -leh et y' - ru - sha - la - yim al rosh

M
A

8 -leh et y' - ru - sha - la - yim al rosh

T
B

8 -leh et y' - ru - sha - la - yim al rosh

31

C.

8 sim - cha - ti im lo a' - a - leh et y' - ru - sha - la -

M
A

8 sim - cha - ti im lo a' - a - leh et y' - ru - sha - la -

T
B

8 sim - cha - ti im lo a' - a - leh et y' - ru - sha - la -

36

C.

8 -yim al rosh sim - cha - ti *molto rit.*

M
A

8 -yim al rosh sim - cha - ti

T
B

8 -yim al rosh sim - cha - ti